NCCA ENTERTAINMENT · LIFETIME / LMN PITCH ONE-SHEET

# THE CAREGIVER'S SECRET

*Written by Kelly R. Tenney · Atlanta*

## LOGLINE

> *A disgraced nurse takes a live-in job caring for a silenced former senator, then discovers the family that hired her chose her on purpose: her one bad mistake makes her the perfect person to blame.*

## THE HOOK IN ONE BREATH

The patient can't speak. The nurse can't afford to quit. The daughter has cameras everywhere except the one room where the truth is being whispered, one card, one letter, one squeeze at a time.

## WHO

Dana Reyes, 34, an ER-trained LPN and single mom to eight-year-old Luca. She lost her last job after initialing two checks she never did and reporting her supervisor. She keeps two columns in her notebook, OBSERVED and ASSESSED, because she will never again sign what she didn't see.

## WHAT THREATENS HER

Priscilla Whitfield-Vance, polished foundation chair and the patient's daughter, who is draining the family charity while her mother recovers from a stroke. Priscilla hired Dana because Dana is compromised. When the money trail gets close, Dana becomes the thief on paper: a torn count sheet, a forged power of attorney and health care proxy, and a threat that reaches her son at school.

## WHY NO ONE CAN SOLVE IT FOR HER

Eleanor can't speak. A county caseworker arrives and finds her sedated. The police can't act on photographs. The agency suspends Dana the moment the family complains. Margot, the loyal housekeeper, is trapped by her own son's secret, and Adrian, the doctor husband, is too tangled up to stop it. Every legitimate route is contaminated, delayed or closed, so going back into the house is the only choice left.

## WHAT SHE STANDS TO LOSE

Her license, her freedom and Luca. She is already days from an eviction notice. The cost of doing right is real from page one and keeps rising.

## THE ENGINE

A speech ladder. Eleanor climbs back toward language one rung at a time: an alphabet card, then HELP, CAREFUL, NO, *Boy first*, then short sentences in the dark that stop the villain cold. Every rung is an escalation the audience feels. The climax turns on a pressure-activated alarm button that sounds only while someone holds it down.

## TRAILER MOMENTS

1. A nurse initials a chart box she never checked, and we watch her life change in one pen stroke.
2. A glass of water, a letter on a card, and the word HELP.
3. A daughter on a camera feed, quoting a whispered voicemail back to Dana word for word.
4. A forged signature, right-handed and perfect, on the hand of a woman who can only sign left-handed and shaky.
5. Dana writes the true pill count on the sheet and photographs it. Priscilla tears the page off along the perforation.
6. The lights go out. Eleanor's thumb holds the alarm button down while the house tries to silence it.
7. A cardboard dog house, one square missing, and the last piece fits the back door.

## TONE AND COMPS

Domestic thriller with a mother-daughter wound at the center: the heart of a family drama, the spine of a conspiracy thriller. Suited to the Lifetime lane: female lead, a threat inside the home, a woman who must trust her own judgment, a clean emotional payoff.

## WHY DANA

She isn't rescued by a hero. She is saved by her own notebook. The thing the villains use against her is the thing she refuses to compromise on again: she writes down what she saw, separately from what she thinks. That is a lead audiences root for, and an arc with a clean before and after.

## PRODUCTION SNAPSHOT

- **Format:** 90 to 120 minute original movie. Current draft: 83 script pages, Rewrite 6.
- **Contained:** one primary estate, plus a nursing facility, a rental house, a hospital stand-in and a school pickup line.

- **Cast:** one lead, one legacy actress with extreme physical and expressive range (Eleanor, mostly nonverbal), one primary antagonist, about four key supports.
- **Stunts and effects:** none. One blackout sequence and one door shove.
- **Atlanta-friendly shoot:** estate, hospital and suburban locations all available regionally.
- **Companion series:** *Under the Plate*, 8 vertical episodes, shot inside the feature's locations. See the separate page.